

Spiny skin
Protective spines grow from small, hard plates just under the skin.

Smell sensors
The skin contains sensitive chemical receptors that pick up the faintest scent of prey.

Simple eyes
An eyespot at the tip of each arm allows the starfish to detect light and shade.

Atlantic star

The common starfish is found along the Atlantic coasts of North America and Europe, down to depths of 1,300 ft (400 m). When food is abundant, especially in spring and summer, they appear in huge numbers along these coastlines.

Greenland

Labrador Sea

NORTH AMERICA

Colder coasts

Common starfish cannot survive and breed in waters as cold as the Arctic, but warm currents flowing up from the equator help push their natural range north, along parts of Greenland's coast.

Mid-ocean realm

A population of starfish lives along the rocky shores, reefs, and sandbanks around the Azores, a group of volcanic islands far out in the Atlantic.

Ocean mixing

Starfish on North America's Atlantic coast are regarded as the same species as those in Europe. Currents in the North Atlantic help mix starfish larvae from both sides of the ocean.

Bermuda



Starfish larvae

Starfish begin their life as eggs, hatching into tiny larvae that drift among minute organisms called plankton, on which they feed. Older larvae (seen here) develop sticky arms that they use to attach to the seabed, before growing their five adult spiny arms.

ATLANTIC OCEAN



IF ONE OF THE **STARFISH'S FIVE LIMBS IS SEVERED**, IT SIMPLY **GROWS ONE BACK**